

Children: Victims of Violence

While the prevalence of violence in today's society affects everyone, the most detrimental impact is on children. For this reason, many young victims become perpetrators later on. These victims are disproportionately children who grow up in impoverished communities where domestic violence and crime are frequent. Uncoincidentally, these are the areas that are underfunded and swept under the rug by the U.S. government. Bryan Stevenson's *Just Mercy*, Spike Lee's *Chi-Raq*, and Luis Alfaro's *Electricidad* each address different aspects of the theme of how violence impacts children in impoverished communities. They portray various outcomes, but, most importantly, how understanding the root of the issue allows structures of power to provide resources for preventing cycles of violence. Showing compassion for people in these situations creates an environment for growth and change, like in *Just Mercy* and *Chi-Raq*. Alternatively, *Electricidad* shows what happens when violence goes unchecked and unaided.

Just Mercy by Bryan Stevenson is about one lawyer's efforts to combat the injustice of the American carceral system. One major issue that stands out is how children are continuously mistreated by a system that is supposed to protect them. By providing insight into the lives of a few of the children he works with, he is able to portray how brutal the justice system is towards children. He also explains just how important it is to consider the cause of crimes committed by children. Oftentimes, children are charged as adults for accidental crimes or crimes that they were forced into committing. Furthermore, many of the children committing crimes are surrounded by violence and abuse that puts them in positions where they feel they have no other option. Stevenson's retelling of one of his client's stories is especially effective at portraying why context matters. After witnessing multiple instances of violence, Charlie shot and killed his mother's abuser. Regardless of these conditions, "the prosecutor insisted that Charlie be tried as

an adult, and he announced that he intended to seek the maximum punishment permitted by law” (Stevenson, 120). This is one of many similar situations that resulted in the incarceration of a youth who is a victim of circumstance. Thanks to Stevenson’s advocacy, Charlie was released early and attended college. Recognizing the cycle of violence that contributes to the perpetuation of crime is crucial to protecting children exposed to violence. It is impossible to break the cycle by placing these children in the hostile environment that is the American carceral system. Many factors go into creating violent communities, but one driving factor is poverty. If people in positions of power provided adequate access to jobs that pay living wages, violence could be significantly reduced. Likewise, implementing centers for domestic violence victims in poor communities can protect those who struggle to escape dangerous homelife. There are many ways people in power can help these children, but first they must listen.

In Spike Lee’s *Chi-Raq*, the eponymous antagonist is the leader of a gang in Chicago. By providing a glimpse into his childhood, Lee is able to depict how Demetrius’ early exposure to violence influences his involvement in a gang. Lee’s choice to reveal these memories during a sex scene adds importance because he shows how even sex, something meant to represent love and connection, is reduced to “fighting, fucking, and screwing” (*Chi-Raq* 1:17). Additionally, *Chi-Raq* explains how Blue Monday, his mother’s boyfriend, introduced him to gang life at twelve. Demetrius’ view of sex as aggressive in nature is rooted in his experience as a child. These memories and lack of understanding about the intimacy of sex contribute to his inability to be vulnerable, which drives him down a path of violence. The association of violence and manhood is another way violence is passed on because children may idolize someone in their life who is seen as powerful, even if their power comes from the abuse of others. Both Demetrius’ father and Blue Monday exemplify this. However, Lee uses Miss Helen to explain that good

people can do bad things and that Demetrius still has a chance at forgiveness. She tells the story of her daughter, Pam, who Demetrius' father killed. Despite his father's legacy, Miss Helen explains that he was a good man, and Chi-Raq still has time to "be a good man" (*Chi-Raq* 1:54). In the end, Chi-Raq turns himself in and admits to the pain he caused his community. Taking accountability and understanding how violence is perpetuated generationally and systemically is the first step towards promoting a safer society. Those who have been victims to violence in the past have the ability to unlearn this behavior and use their experiences to teach others.

Luis Alfaro's "Electricidad" addresses the impact of violence on youth by recounting the development of a young man training as gang leader. Despite the fact that his father "beat" his mother and "made [her] scared of the world", Orestes remains innocent (Alfaro, 65). Clemencia describes Orestes as her "most sensitive one" because he is still a child even though he is expected to fill the position of gang leader (Alfaro, 105). Alfaro shows his evolution throughout the play when he first appears with his advisor. He is being trained in the cholo ways, and Nino says to him "Good cholo" (Alfaro, 52). This phrase exemplifies how violence is a learned behavior because Orestes is addressed similarly to a dog learning tricks. Orestes' description is almost mechanical, which shows how he must lack emotion to fulfill his role as gang leader. Alfaro continuously portrays Orestes' innocence by showing how he does not "have the 'cholo instinct,'" meaning that he is inherently good (Alfaro, 71). By setting up Orestes' character, he dramatizes the shift in personality at the end of the play as a direct result of the violence surrounding his life. After being coerced by his sister, Orestes ends the life of his mother. This is the act that ultimately breaks him. In the end, his grandmother says that he is "un demonio" because he becomes utterly corrupted by his actions and the actions of others leading up to this breaking point (Alfaro, 108). Alfaro's play is an example of how drastically an environment of

violence can skew one's values and morals, resulting in the destruction of their innocence. He also illustrates how detrimental it can be to a community to completely disregard victims of violence. Orestes had the potential to be a good person, but due to surrounding influence, he became worse than his predecessors.

In Guterman and Cameron's "Assessing the Impact of Community Violence on Children and Youths", they explain that the effects of violence on children are detrimental to their mental wellbeing and development. They also convey that the lack of research surrounding this issue correlates with the deficit of resources dedicated to preventing these circumstances. Guterman and Cameron outline the categories necessary to assess how at risk a child is and claim that their method is vital to "significantly reduc[ing] community violence and its resulting fear and trauma" (Guterman and Cameron, 502-503). Bryan Stevenson outlines the importance of outside intervention in order to protect child victims, and Spike Lee shows how violence impacts the whole community. Luis Alfaro introduces a more pessimistic story that warns against what will happen if people in power fail to address this violence. These stories work together to cover all aspects that go into the perpetuation of violence and its lasting impact. I agree that community violence, along with domestic violence, have a significant negative impact on child development and overall health. Raising awareness of these problems is an important first step to addressing and eventually combating violence. Each of the primary sources supports Guterman and Cameron's assertion that these experiences are especially harmful to children. While Bryan Stevenson's example, Charlie, commits a terrible act out of fear, he gains redemption for his actions. Stevenson's willingness to protect Charlie from the corrupt justice system led to his ability to thrive as an adult. Spike Lee's *Chi-Raq* grows up surrounded by gang life and violence, but is persuaded by his community to own up to what he has done and accept his punishment,

thereby protecting his community from the violence he took part in. Both of these examples support the idea that providing resources and assistance to these children can eliminate lasting effects of communal violence. On the other hand, Luis Alfaro's Orestes succumbs to the pressure of his sister and loses himself to violence. The person he becomes in the end is unrecognizable. Unfortunately, exposure to violence can cause irreparable damage to the character of a child when left without help. Moreover, all of these stories are told in minority, impoverished communities. The reality is that "the absolute [number] of children and youths encountering community violence...[is] even higher for children of color[. There is a] 24 percent [projected increase] for African American teenagers and [a] 47 percent [projected increase] for Latino teenagers" at the time of the study (Guterman and Cameron, 496). These children are disadvantaged from factors they have no control over, and using characters that fit these demographics assert the point that people of color experience dramatically higher rates of violence. This leads to the stigmatization of impoverished communities as dangerous, even though the government's lack of concern surrounding these communities is what continues the cycle of violence and poverty. As portrayed by Stevenson, Lee, and Alfaro, Guterman and Cameron claim that "the remorseless acts of aggression and retribution associated with gang violence may, in part, be the result of the 'truncated' moral development of children growing up in persistently dangerous neighborhoods" (498). Therefore, it can be concluded that exposure to various types of violence can potentially, and likely, cause harm to children. Using resources to promote more research about the effects of violence and confronting this issue by providing resources to those impacted is necessary to reducing community and domestic violence and ensuring the safety of children across America. People in power need to provide aid to these communities instead of ignoring them. There is evidence that violent upbringings result in

violent behaviors, so it is vital that funding be provided to not only protect current victims, but also to prevent the creation of future victims.